

IN CONTEXT

GENRE

Drama

DIRECTOR

François Truffaut

WRITERS

**François Truffaut,
Marcel Moussy**

STARS

**Jean-Pierre Léaud, Claire
Maurier, Albert Rémy,
Guy Decomble**

BEFORE

1955 Truffaut's first short, *The Visit*, is the tale of a bungled proposal of love. It is screened only for a handful of friends.

AFTER

1960 Jean-Luc Godard follows his colleague Truffaut into cinema with *À bout de souffle*.**1962** Truffaut's *Jules et Jim* is a story of a love triangle set at the time of World War I.**1968** Jean-Pierre Léaud reprises the role of Antoine in *Stolen Kisses*.

Much has been written by critics about *The 400 Blows*. Indeed, the movie's director, François Truffaut, was one of France's best-known film critics before he decided to show the world how he thought movies should be made. He and the other filmmakers who led the French New Wave in the late 1950s and early 1960s believed that a director was an author (*auteur*) and the camera a pen (a "camera-pen," or *caméra-stylo*).

Semiautobiography

The 400 Blows is in part a painfully personal memoir describing Truffaut's Parisian childhood, with certain names and events changed, not to disguise the victims, but to express something new and true. The young Truffaut becomes Antoine Doinel (Jean-Pierre Léaud), a fledgling troublemaker who is constantly accused of distorting the facts. "Your parents say you are always lying," says the psychiatrist sent to figure him out. "Sometimes I'd tell them the truth and they still wouldn't believe me," replies the boy, "so I prefer to lie."

Antoine reads the works of Honoré de Balzac, and when he adapts the author's work for a school

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I demand that a film express either the joy of making cinema or the agony of making cinema. I am not at all interested in anything in between.
François Truffaut

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essay, using the thoughts and feelings to express his own emotions, he is punished by a teacher. It's an act of homage condemned as plagiarism, and Antoine's response is an act of delinquency: he steals a typewriter from his stepfather's workplace.

Recreating adolescence

There is often romance in youthful rebellion, but *The 400 Blows* is not a nostalgic work. It does not look back on adolescence from an adult's point of view, but rather recreates it in the present tense,

**François Truffaut** Director

It's a brave film critic who picks up a camera and directs a movie of their own. François Truffaut did just that with *The 400 Blows*, and his courage paid off—the movie was hailed as a masterpiece, and Truffaut went on to direct more than 20 movies before his death in 1984.

As a journalist writing for the influential film magazine *Cahiers du Cinéma*, Truffaut pioneered the *auteur* theory, a controversial school of thought that identified

the director as a movie's author. Truffaut was critical of most contemporary French movies, earning the nickname "The Gravedigger of French Cinema." But after *The 400 Blows*, his reputation was transformed.

Key movies

1959 *The 400 Blows*
1962 *Jules et Jim*
1966 *Fahrenheit 451*
1973 *Day for Night*